

CHOSEN: THE STORY BEFORE THE MANGER

SCENE 12 - GOOD NEWS / SHEPHERDS / FINALE

CURRENT - COMPANY VERSION

Target Runtime	9-9½ minutes; maximum 10 minutes
Musical Material	Continuation of "Silent Night" -> shepherd underscore -> "Welcome to Nazareth" transformed finale
Status	CURRENT - COMPANY VERSION
Characters	Mary, Joseph, Jesus, Shepherd 1, Shepherd 2, Young Shepherd, Angel Voice, Eli, Anna, Nia, Simon, Wise Men, Mary's Friends, Joseph's Friends, Children, Villagers, Dancers, Praise Team / Choir, Full Company

CONTINUOUS FROM SCENE 11

No blackout. The baby has cried. Mary has invited Joseph closer and placed the child into his arms. We begin inside the silence Scene 11 created.

Joseph looks down at the child. Mary watches him. Another small sound from the baby.

MARY

You're good at that.

JOSEPH

I have no idea what I'm doing.

MARY

Neither does he.

Joseph looks at the child again. A tiny smile.

JOSEPH

Then we'll learn together.

Joseph adjusts the cloth around the child with extraordinary care.

"SILENT NIGHT"

Only now does the quiet musical phrase from Scene 11 continue. One voice. Then another. No full choir. Mary, Joseph and the child remain the center. Anna may remain just outside the family image.

As the final phrase settles, Joseph gently returns the child to Mary.

A separate pool of darkness slowly appears elsewhere. The manger remains visible.

THE SHEPHERD FIELD

Night. Cold. Open land. Shepherd 1, Shepherd 2 and the Young Shepherd are working.

YOUNG SHEPHERD

Come on.

Nothing.

SHEPHERD 2

Having trouble?

YOUNG SHEPHERD

A little.

SHEPHERD 2

It's a sheep.

YOUNG SHEPHERD

I know.

Shepherd 1 redirects the animal.

SHEPHERD 1

Don't argue with sheep.

SHEPHERD 2

You won't win.

YOUNG SHEPHERD

I'm cold.

SHEPHERD 2

We're all cold.

SHEPHERD 1

Morning will come.

YOUNG SHEPHERD

Good.

A tiny laugh. Then the animals become still. Shepherd 1 notices first.

SHEPHERD 1

Wait.

SHEPHERD 2

What?

SHEPHERD 1

Listen.

SILENCE.

SHEPHERD 2

I don't hear anything.

SHEPHERD 1

Exactly.

A low atmospheric sound begins. The Young Shepherd looks into the changing darkness.

YOUNG SHEPHERD

What's that?

SHEPHERD 1

Stay close.

HEAVEN INTERRUPTS

The night transforms. The shepherds are surrounded by something impossible.

ANGEL VOICE

Do not be afraid.

The shepherds freeze.

SHEPHERD 2

I'm trying.

A nervous breath of laughter may release, then disappears.

ANGEL VOICE

I bring you good news of great joy for all people.

ANGEL VOICE

Tonight, in the city of David, a Savior has been born.

ANGEL VOICE

You will know Him by this sign: you will find a baby wrapped in cloth, lying in a manger.

YOUNG SHEPHERD

A manger?

HEAVENLY VOICES

GLORY TO GOD IN THE HIGHEST!

Powerful. Brief. EVERYTHING STOPS. Night returns. SILENCE.

SHEPHERD 2

Did that really happen?

SHEPHERD 1

Yes.

YOUNG SHEPHERD

Let's go.

SHEPHERD 2

Right now?

SHEPHERD 1

Right now.

They move.

THE SEARCH

SHEPHERD UNDERSCORE. Bethlehem reappears around them: narrow passages, sleeping households, travelers and closed doors.

SHEPHERD 2

How do we find one baby in Bethlehem?

SHEPHERD 1

Remember the sign.

YOUNG SHEPHERD

A manger.

SHEPHERD 2

So we're looking for a baby where babies usually aren't.

The Young Shepherd notices Eli and Anna's lodging property.

YOUNG SHEPHERD

There.

KNOCK. KNOCK. Eli opens the door, exhausted. Anna appears behind him.

ELI

Yes?

SHEPHERD 1

Forgive us. We're looking for a baby.

ELI

A baby?

YOUNG SHEPHERD

In a manger.

Eli and Anna exchange a look. Anna immediately understands.

ANNA

Eli.

Eli looks toward the rear of the property.

ELI

Come with me.

ANNA

Quietly.

The shepherds follow.

THE SHEPHERDS ARRIVE

Eli and Anna lead the shepherds toward the animal shelter. Their excitement becomes uncertainty as they realize they are approaching a sleeping family, not a palace. Joseph hears footsteps and rises.

JOSEPH

Eli?

ELI

It's all right.

Anna gestures gently toward the shepherds.

ANNA

They came looking for the baby.

Joseph looks at Mary. Then at the strangers.

JOSEPH

Why?

SHEPHERD 1

We were told we'd find Him here.

The Young Shepherd sees the feeding trough. Stops.

YOUNG SHEPHERD

The manger.

SILENCE.

AT THE MANGER

Mary watches these strangers carefully.

MARY

How did you know?

SHEPHERD 1

An angel came to us.

Mary and Joseph exchange a look.

SHEPHERD 2

He said a Savior had been born tonight.

SHEPHERD 1

And that we'd find Him here.

The Young Shepherd looks at the manger.

YOUNG SHEPHERD

We found Him.

SILENCE. Mary looks at the child.

SHEPHERD 1

I'm glad we came.

MARY

So am I.

THE NAME

The Young Shepherd looks at the child, then at Joseph.

YOUNG SHEPHERD

What's His name?

SILENCE. Give this time. Joseph looks at the child, then Mary. Mary looks back at Joseph.

JOSEPH

His name is...

Music suspends.

JOSEPH

Jesus.

The name lands simply. The Young Shepherd kneels first. Shepherd 1 follows. Shepherd 2 slowly kneels.

NIA AND SIMON RETURN

A warm pool of light appears downstage. Nia and Simon step into it. Behind them, Mary, Joseph, Jesus and the kneeling shepherds remain visible. Orchestra continues softly underneath.

NIA

Remember Nazareth?

SIMON

Small town. Ordinary people.

NIA

Mary thought she knew what came next.

SIMON

Joseph did too.

Beat.

NIA

Then everything changed.

SIMON

And the story kept moving.

NIA

Beyond Nazareth.

SIMON

Beyond Bethlehem.

The STAR begins to intensify.

NIA

And more people were already on the road.

Nia and Simon look outward. A familiar musical sound begins almost beneath perception.

COMPANY / ORCHESTRA

OHHH-OH... OOOH-OOH-OOH...

The musical DNA of Scene 1. MUSIC SWELLS.

FINAL MUSICAL NUMBER - "WELCOME TO NAZARETH" TRANSFORMED

Three Wise Men appear in the aisles and begin a slow, dignified procession toward the stage.

RECOGNITION

The opening musical identity becomes unmistakable. Mary's friends, Joseph's friends, children, villagers, dancers, praise team and choir return as the company telling the story. The manger remains visible and central.

COMPANY

OHHH-OH... OOOH-OOH-OOH...

EXPANSION

The Wise Men continue their procession. Children and Nia/Simon begin with recognizable Scene 1 movement vocabulary. Friends layer into the architecture. Shepherds rise and join the celebration.

DANCE

The music opens into the final choreographic celebration. Use transformed Scene 1 movement vocabulary. Mary and Joseph remain with the child rather than joining the full-out choreography.

VOCAL PEAK

Children, friends, shepherds, praise team / choir and full company layer into the production's largest musical scale.

FINAL SUNG STATEMENT. FINAL CHORD.

SURRENDER

Over the final sustained musical and lighting counts, the company simplifies. Dancers finish their final traveling phrase and become still. Eyelines return toward the child.

FINAL IMAGE

Mary, Joseph and Jesus remain low and central. The Young Shepherd may kneel nearest the family. Shepherds occupy one side; Wise Men the opposite side, gifts visible. Nia and Simon remain offset. Friends, children, villagers, praise team and company form layered heights farther out. Dancers frame the outer picture.

HOLD. One. Two. Three. FAST, CLEAN BLACKOUT.

END OF CHOSEN: THE STORY BEFORE THE MANGER